

With the Grace of G-d

בס"ד

בר מצוה
של



ב' דראש חודש טבת ז' דחנוכה
ה'תשס"ב



Bar Mitzvah
of



Sunday, December 16, 2001
7th Day of Chanukah, 1 Tevet, 5762

We welcome you to David's Bar Mitzvah. We are so happy that all of you are able to share in this Simcha (joyous occasion) as David is called to the Torah. This booklet has been prepared to enable those of you who are attending a Bar Mitzvah for the first time to acquire some understanding of the worship service and the significance that this ceremony represents in David's life.

Deborah and Larry

Honors at the Ceremony of the Torah Reading:

Open Ark:

Take out Torah:

Aliyot:

1st:

2nd:

3rd:

4th:

Hagbah:

G'lila:

Open Ark:

Return Torah Scroll:

D'var Torah:

Parents Charge:

Prayer for Peace:

Ushers:

The significance of the Bar and Bat Mitzvah

Jewish people are a nation in the highest and best sense of the word. Bar/Bat mitzvah is the moment in the Jewish life cycle that most deeply defines who Jews are as a nation. The Torah is our tribal wisdom. It reminds us that our lives have a rhythm and a purpose. As the soul is to the individual body, the Torah is the soul of the Jewish people. The ceremony of Bar/Bat Mitzvah, celebrating the Torah, is a link in an unbroken chain of thousands of years of Jewish tradition.

The words **Bar/Bat Mitzvah** literally mean, “son/daughter of the commandment.” This means old enough to be responsible for **Mitzvot**. Mitzvot are commandments that a Jewish person does in order to not only live a Jewish life, but also sanctify life.

Bar/Bat Mitzvah is a young man who has reached the age 13 plus one day and a young woman reaching the age of 12. Age 13 is the age of spiritual and moral choices. An opinion in Midrash is that at age 13, Abraham looked at the heavens and concluded there was a G-d. Rabbinic sources say that at the age of 13 the child becomes endowed with both the **yetser hatov** (the good inclination) and the **yetser hara** (the evil inclination). The age of 13 is therefore a crossroads of spiritual, moral, and religious maturity.

On a deeper level, just as their bodies are growing and changing in a new way, so too their souls are growing and changing. The **Kabbalistic** tradition tells us that a person's spiritual being has two souls, an animal, “selfish”, soul, and a G-dly soul. The G-dly soul, the **neshamah**, comes into awareness at bar/bat mitzvah time. This soul is what gives a person the ability to make conscious, rational decisions.

The Synagogue

Mechitzah

As you entered the synagogue today, the men and women were asked to sit in separate sections. A Mechitzah is the physical separation between men and women during prayer that creates a sacred space for each gender to connect with Hashem (G-d) without distraction.

Kippah or Yarmulke

The Kippah covering ones head is a traditional Jewish sign of respect for G-d. Covering ones head signifies that there is something higher than mankind. It is customary for males to wear the Kippah. Women may also choose to wear some sort of head covering. Ushers will provide you with a Kippah today as you enter the Shul. Please join us in participating in this tradition. Literally, **Kippah** means “covering”, and **Yarmulka** means “Yere Malka”, fear of the King, G-d, inspired by the head covering.

Tallit (prayer shawl)

Tallit is the Aramaic word for “to cover”. The Tallit reflects many levels of religious symbolism. The Tallit consists of three parts: the garment itself, a collar and Tzitzit. The Tallit (known also as **Tallit Gadol**) is a four-cornered tasseled garment with **Tzitzit** which wraps around the body, worn by many boys over the age of 13 and by male adults during prayer. Girls over the age of 12 and women are not obligated to, yet may also choose to wear them.

Tzitzit means “fringes”. According to Kaballah, it is that the Tzitzit are a symbol of the 613 mitzvot. This is equivalent to the total number of commandments given by G-d to the Jewish people in the Torah. The five Hebrew letters that comprise the Hebrew word Tzitzit each have a numerical value (the Hebrew alphabet doubles as a code of sorts), and the total numerical value of “tzitzit” is 600. Add the numbers eight and five, which represent the eight strings and 5 knots of each tassel and it adds

up to 613. Wearing Tzitzit therefore is a visible reminder to observe all of G-d's commandments.

The alternate **Tallit Katan** is worn over the shoulders under one's garments, and may be worn at any time.

Tefillin

Tefillin comes from the same root as the Hebrew word Tefillah, meaning "prayer". That root is **Tofel**, meaning connection (to G-d). Tefillin are given to a boy on his Bar Mitzvah as something sacred and specific as a sign of his coming of age in the Jewish community. Putting on Tefillin interrupts the continuous demands of everyday life to rejuvenate the connection to G-d. Tefillin is put on daily except Shabbat and Holydays.

Tefillin are palm-sized hard leather boxes that contain sacred parchment writings in Hebrew. They are donned with long leather straps. The prayers of the Shema and the Vahavtah among others are written on the parchment.

The Mitzvah of Tefillin and its practice facilitate the unity of mind and heart, intellect, and emotion. Placed on the hand opposite the heart and on the head, the Tefillin signify the submission of one's actions, heart and mind, to G-d, as well as the rule of intellect over emotion. It is not sufficient that only one's feelings, thought and speech be in accordance with the Torah, but one must observe the Mitzvot in actual deed to validate sincerity and evidence of one's conviction.

Torah

The Torah literally means "instruction". It also means "light". Most specifically, the word Torah refers to the Five Books of Moses: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. The Torah is a scroll flawlessly handwritten on parchment by a scribe. It contains exactly 304,808 Hebrew letters and takes six to twelve months to complete.

The Torah is the truest, most core representation of Judaism itself. It is the heart, mind, and soul of Judaism. The Torah

contains Jewish civil and religious law, early history and origins of the Jewish people. The Torah is read in synagogues on Mondays and Thursdays in addition to Shabbat, holidays and Rosh Chodesh. Today we mark both the holiday of **Chanukah** and **Rosh Chodesh**, the new month, of Tevet.

The Day

Rosh Chodesh (The new moon)

The Jewish calendar is based on the cycles of the new moon. The first day of the Hebrew month and the Jewish holidays each year are determined by the new moon. It begins with the crescent of the new moon. Rosh Chodesh is symbolic of the Jews' **waxing** and **waning**, as the moon does. It is a time to connect with many cycles and patterns in our lives, an opportunity to renew our hopes and dreams, and an invitation to reconnect with G-d's presence in the world.

The waning of Jewish renewal occurred with the Syrian-Greek attempt to eradicate our tradition thousands of years ago by ending our observances. Instead, the Jewish people rose up in defense of the Torah and the Holy Temple, and their triumph and waxing is commemorated through the Festival of Chanukah, the festival of light and renewal. December 16th marks Rosh Chodesh Tevet and the seventh day of Chanukah.

Chanukah

Chanukah means "dedication". It is an eight-day holiday commemorating the rededication of the second temple after a period of enemy occupation. It is a joyous holiday, celebrated with the lighting of a Menorah to commemorate the miracle of the small jar of pure olive oil lasting for eight days. The Menorah is the eight-branched candelabra that is lit every night. Special foods are prepared like potato latkes, jelly donuts, anything made with oil are eaten and games like dreidel are played. Gifts are exchanged. This is a very family oriented holiday.

The miracle of **pure oil** has special significance in light of the Greek attempt at Hellenization of Judaism. Only rational

traditions were meant to be kept, and the irrational, or the holy, discarded. This may be compared to the jar of oil which has been opened, the seal broken, and contaminated. The Jews led by the Maccabees insisted on maintaining that purity of oil, the purity and holy nature of Judaism.

The Service

Siddur

The books we shall use during the service are the Siddur (the prayer book) that contains the service. The books are in Hebrew with English translations. The Siddur open in the opposite directions from the English books because Hebrew is read from right to left.

The Morning Service

The service this morning is divided into three major parts: The **Shacharit** prayers, the **Torah** service, and the **Musaf** service.

Shacharit

The morning service, which consists of four parts:

- **Hodu**, thankfulness to G-d.
- **Pesukei D’Zimra**, words of praise to G-d.
- The **Shema**. This is the most important part of the Torah. It is a prayer declaring there is only one God.
- The **Amida**. According to the Talmud, a spine is made up of 18 bones. The Amida is comprised originally of 18 blessings and is the spine of the Jewish people. The Amidah is the way we stand up straight as Jews and it is the way we orient ourselves. The Amida is said silently and while standing. It is a time of thanks to G-D, personal reflection, and personal prayers.
- We conclude with the **Hallel** service of additional praise of G-d to honor Rosh Chodesh.

Torah Service

The Torah service is the central part of the service. The Torah is removed from the **ark**. We ask that everyone please stand when the ark is opened and closed. David’s father will pass the **scroll** to him, symbolizing the passing along of the responsibility for observing its laws and precepts. This is followed by a procession around the synagogue by David, so that all the members of the congregation can be close to the Torah and touch it. The reading of the Torah is entirely in Hebrew. The Torah is divided into weekly Torah portions that will take an entire year to read.

As the Torah is read, family members and friends are honored with an **Aliyah**. An Aliyah is the honor of reciting traditional blessing before and after each portion is read. David will be honored with the last Aliyah and he will have the privilege of chanting his portion from the Torah. After he is finished, there is a tradition of tossing sweets (which you were given when you arrived) at this point in the service as a way of wishing David a good life, filled with pleasant things. At this time we also sing a song wishing David a life filled with happiness. After the Torah reading, the Rabbi and David will address the congregation on his interpretation of the concepts and teachings of his portion. This is called a **D’var Torah**.

Musaf Service

This is the final portion of the service when Musaf (meaning “additional”) prayers are recited to honor Rosh Chodesh. In these final prayers, the **Aleinu** (thanking G-d for creating things, and all G-d has done throughout history) is said. It reprises all of the service’s major themes and wraps them up in a final hope: ONEness. The **Mourner’s Kaddish** (the Kaddish is a moment of praise for G-d which helps us remember those who have gone before us, led the way, and are no longer with us. Those who are in mourning will rise to recite the Kaddish prayer).

The service will conclude with some words by David’s parents, a blessing for David, and a blessing for peace.